4 Socio-Religious Reform Movements

Introduction

In the early 19th century, Indian society was marked by rigid caste structures and practices contrary to humanitarian values, justified in the name of religion. This called for change, leading to movements focused on reforming and modernizing social and religious norms.

Nature of Socio-Religious Movements

- Recognition of the connections between religious and social issues characterised the reform perspectives of the movements and their leaders. They tried to alter social norms and customs by using religious concepts.
- To abolish caste distinctions in society, for instance, **Keshub Chandra Sen** interpreted the "**Unity of godhead and brotherhood of mankind**".
- The **main social issues** that the reform movements sought to address were:
  - Casteism and untouchability
  - Emancipation of women, which involved addressing sati, infanticide, child marriage, and widow marriage; and education to promote societal enlightenment.
  - Religious issues such as Polytheism, idolatry, Religious superstitions, and Priestly exploitation.

Reformist and Revivalist Movement

- Both reformist and revivalist movements contributed to the advancement of socio-religious reforms in society, which finally paved the way for the emergence of a contemporary and forward-thinking society.

Reformist Movement	Revivalist Movement
❖ These groups relied more on reason and rationalism to conclude whether to embrace or reject a social custom or religious institution. ❖ Modern Western values in the sociocultural realm, such as gender equality and the freedom to select one's life partner, liberal thoughts etc. were the characteristics of these movements. ❖ Leaders of these movements refused to completely restructure society along Western lines, despite accepting modern Western principles. ❖ Instead of Westernization, modernity was their goal. ❖ **For Example**: Brahmo Samaj, the Aligarh movement	❖ These movements leaned firmly on the lost purity of religion they were trying to revive. ❖ Movements toward revivalism were more in tune with tradition than with reason and conscience. ❖ These initiatives sought to show the progressivism and rationalism of traditional Indian sociocultural beliefs. ❖ **For Example**: Wahabi Movement, Deoband Movement, and Arya Samaj Movement.

Reasons for Socio-Religious Reform Movements

1. **Response to Colonial Critique:**
   - **British Rule and Criticism:** The British colonial authorities and Christian missionaries often criticized Indian social and religious practices as barbaric and backward, particularly sati (the practice of widow burning), child marriage, and the caste system.
   - **Example:** Raja Ram Mohan Roy founded the Brahmo Samaj in 1828 partly as a response to these criticisms. He aimed to purify Hinduism and abolish practices like Sati, which he successfully campaigned against, leading to the Sati Abolition Act in 1829.
2. **Desire for Social Reform:**
   - **Internal Social Critique:** Many Indian intellectuals began to question and critique their own social practices, recognizing the need for reform to remove practices that were seen as regressive and oppressive.
   - **Example:** Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar championed the cause for widow remarriage, leading to the Hindu Widows' Remarriage Act of 1856, which was a direct result of his advocacy and reformist ideology.

3. **Rise of Educated Middle Class:**
   - **Western Education:** The introduction of Western education by the British led to the emergence of a new class of educated Indians who were exposed to liberal and progressive ideas.
   - **Example:** The Young Bengal Movement, inspired by Henry Louis Vivian Derozio, was an intellectual and social movement by young men in the Bengal region, who advocated for rationalism and critiqued existing religious and social norms.
4. **Religious Revivalism:**
   - **Need to Revive and Rationalize Religion:** In response to the perceived threat from Western cultural and religious domination, there was a movement to revive Indian religions by removing what were considered corruptions and interpolations over the centuries.
   - **Example:** Swami Dayananda Saraswati founded the Arya Samaj in 1875, which sought to return Hinduism to its supposed pure Vedic roots, emphasizing the authority of the Vedas and denouncing idol worship and caste restrictions.
5. **Empowerment of Women and Marginalized Groups:**
   - **Social Injustice:** There was a growing awareness about the plight of women and lower caste groups who suffered from severe social discrimination and lack of basic rights.
   - **Example:** Jyotirao Phule established the Satyashodhak Samaj in 1873 to fight against caste oppression and promote social equality. He was also a strong advocate for the education of women and lower castes.
6. **Impact of Global Movements:**
   - **Influence of Global Ideologies:** The impact of global movements such as abolitionism, suffragism, and other reform movements influenced Indian thinkers and leaders to implement similar changes in their society.
   - **Example:** Pandita Ramabai, influenced by the global women's suffrage movement, advocated for the emancipation of Indian women and their right to education.

Method Applied to Bring Reforms

The following **four techniques were used** in an effort to alter socio-religious practices:

1. **Reforms from Within**: Rammohan Roy invented this technique. According to him, any **reform needed to come from within society itself** by raising people's awareness in order to be successful. People advocating this method had published tracts and held discussions and debates on various social issues.
   - **For example, Rammohan's** campaign against sati**, Vidyasagar's** pamphlets on widow marriage, and **B.M.Malabari's** efforts to increase the age of consent.
2. **Reforms through Legislation**: It was symbolized in the effectiveness of government action. The proponents of this approach held that government assistance is necessary for reform initiatives to be made successful.
   - **For example,** individuals like **Keshub Chandra Sen in Bengal, Mahadev Govind Ranade in Maharashtra, and Veeresalingam in Andhra** made an appeal to the government to support legislation that would increase the age of consent, legalize civil unions, and allow widow marriages.
3. **Reforms through Symbol of Change**: It was an effort to produce symbols of change through individual, unconventional activity.
   - **For example, 'Derozians' or 'Young Bengal',** as an example, symbolized an aggressive stream within the reform movement. They were heavily influenced by **the new thought of the Western world** and had a rigidly logical approach to social issues.
4. **Reforms through Social Work**: The Ramakrishna Mission, Arya Samaj, and Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar's activities all displayed this methodology.
   - **For example,** the Ramakrishna Mission and the Arya Samaj engaged in social work through which they attempted to spread concepts of reform and regeneration.

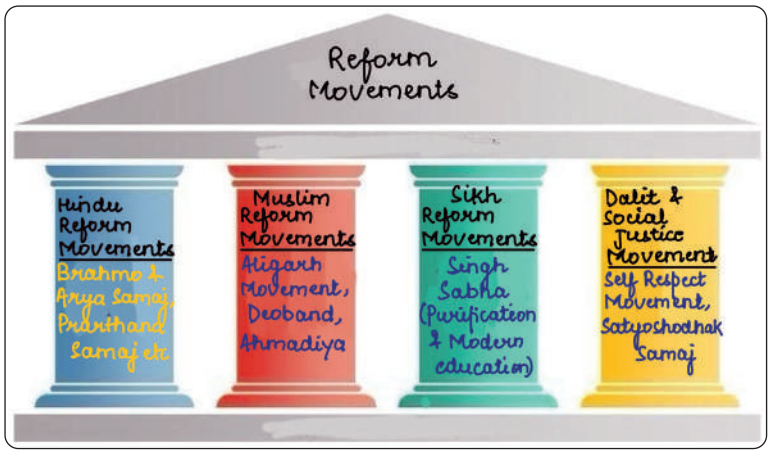

Fig. 4.1: Major Reform Movements
Diagram Type: *Pillar*

Hindu Reform Movements

Hindu socio-religious reform movements were mostly **reformist** in nature, however, some movements, like the Arya Samaj movement, Ramakrishna Mission etc. were revivalist.

Raja Ram Mohan Roy and Brahmo Samaj (UPSC 2021)

- **About**: He was an outstanding scholar, humanist, and patriot. His life was dedicated to the social, religious, intellectual, and political renewal of Indians because of his profound love for the nation.
- **Organisation Associated:** Atmiya Sabha (**1814**), Brahmo Sabha (**1828**) (later renamed as Brahmo Samaj)
- **Contribution:**
  - **Focus on Scientific Temperament**: Condemned polytheism, the veneration of idols, and supported human reason and conscience as they are more important than any religious text.
  - **Attacked on Superstition:** Discarded belief in incarnations and encouraged morality, goodness, and worship of an unchangeable, eternal god.
  - **Protest for marginalized groups**: Criticised caste system and prevailed untouchability in society.
  - **Women empowerment**: Opposed practices like Sati, Polygamy, and Child marriage. With his effort, Sati's custom was abolished in 1829.
  - **Modern Education**: He was involved in the establishment of Calcutta's Hindu College (Presidency College). Additionally, he supported on his own resources an English school in Calcutta.
- **Literary Works:**
  - Tuhfat-ul-Muwahhidin (A Gift to Monotheism)
  - Precepts of Jesus (1820)
  - Translation of Vedas and Upanishads into Bengali
  - Samvad Kaumudi
  - Mirat-ul-Akbar (Persian)
  - Atmiya Sabha Publication (Bengal Gazette)

Dayanand Saraswati and Arya Samaj

- **About**: As a noble Hindu reform movement in Modern India, Mool Shanker (later known as Swami Dayanand Saraswati) founded the **Arya Samaj in 1875.**
- **Associated Organizations:** Arya Samaj, Dayananda AngloVedic (D.A.V.) College in 1886, Shuddhi (purification) movement.
- **Literary Works**: Satyarth Prakash
- **Shuddhi Movement:**
  - The Arya Samajists witnessed the Sudhi movement as a powerful tool for bringing about India's socio-religious and political unification of India.
  - It involved in the reconversion of Hindus who earlier converted to other religions either voluntarily or forcibly but were now ready to return to Hinduism, as well as also focussed on preventing any more conversion.
- **Contribution:**
  - **Society free from discrimination:** Vision of a united (religiously, socially, and nationally) class- and caste-free society. Freedom from foreign occupation, and everyone practices the Aryan religion.
  - **Back to the Vedas**: Vedic learning and religious purity were revived. He believed that all of the knowledge that God had given to man was contained in the Vedas and that the foundations of modern science could also be found there.
  - **Attacked Superstitious beliefs:** Hindu orthodoxy, caste rigidities, untouchability, idolatry, polytheism, faith in magic, charms, and animal sacrifices, among other things, were attacked.
  - **Modern Education:** He preferred learning about Western science. Associates of Dayanand Saraswati such as Lala hansraj, Lala Lajpat Rai Lala lal Chand founded Dayanand Anglo Vedic College (DAV).

Rama Krishna Mission and Swami Vivekananda

- Mystic Ramkrishna Paramhansa turned to the age-old practices of **renunciation, meditation, and devotion** in order to find religious salvation.
- He was a saintly man who stressed that there are many paths to God and salvation and that serving others is serving God. He also recognized the fundamental similarity of all religions.
- **Ramakrishna Movement**
  - The **Ramakrishna Movement** was founded on the teachings of Ramakrishna Paramhansa in **May 1897**.
  - The movement's **two main goals** were to:
    - Establish a group of monks committed to renunciation and practical spirituality, from whom teachers and workers would be dispatched to spread the Vedic message of universal truth as exemplified in the life of Ramakrishna.

- Continue preaching, and charitable works, observing all men, women, and children as true manifestations of the Divine regardless of caste, creed, or colour.

- **Swami Vivekananda**
  - He represented India at the inaugural **Parliament of Religion in Chicago**, Illinois, in 1893 where he preached healthy balance between spritualism and materialism.
  - Subscribed to the **Vedanta system**.
  - Propagated the philosophy of **service to jiva** (living objects) is **the worship of Siva**.

Young Bengal Movement (UPSC 2021)

- **Henry Vivian Derozio:**
  - The movement was led by **Henry Vivian Derozio.**
  - The first nationalist poet of modern India, who was also an inspiration for progressive trends and a result of the **French Revolution.**
  - The **Hindu college in Kolkata** served as the birthplace of the Young Bengal movement, a radical effort to reform Hindu society.
- **Derozio encouraged his students the following:**
  - To think critically and rationally
  - To challenge all forms of authority
  - To value liberty, equality, and freedom
  - To reject outmoded practices and traditions by drawing inspiration from the great French Revolution
  - Motivated to raise voice in the favour of **education and women's rights**

M.G. Ranade and Prarthana Samaj

- **Dr. Atma Ram Pandurang** founded the Prarthana Samaj in Bombay in **1867.** It accomplished in Maharashtra what the Brahmo Samaj did in Bengal.
- The Samaj was established with the intention of reforming Hinduism and promoting the worship of one God.
- **Mahadev Govind Ranade and R.G. Bhandarkar** were the great leaders of the Prarthana Samaj.
- There were the **following four points of the social agenda** of Prarthana Samaj:

1. Disapproval of the caste system
2. Women's education
3. Widow Remarriage
4. Raising the age of marriage for both males and females

- **Contribution of Mahadev Govind Ranade:**
  - **Philosophy:** Religious and social reforms are integrated into each other. For success in social, economic and political spheres, religious reforms should be flexible.
  - **Organization**: The Widow Remarriage Association (**1861**) and the Deccan Education Society were founded. He also established the **Poona Sarvajanik Sabha in 1870.**
  - **Against Strict Ban of Idol Worship:** Prarthana Samaj **did not advocate a strict ban on idol worship** despite being influenced by the ideas of Brahmo Samaj.
  - **Caste System:** The Samaj was not strict for an explicit separation from the caste system.

Jyotiba Phule and Satyasodhak Samaj

- The '**Satyashodhak' Samaj** (**Truth Seekers' Society**) was founded by **Jyotiba Phule** in **1873.** The depressed communities gained a sense of class identity as an outcome of this movement. Phule used the symbol of **Rajah Bali** as opposed to the Brahmins' symbol of Rama.
- **Objective**
  - Social services
  - Spreading education among women and members of lower castes
  - Aim for the elimination of Social and economic inequality
- **Literary Works**
  - Sarvajanik Satyadharma and Ghulamgiri
  - Both became a source of inspiration for the common masses

Annie Basent and Theosophical Society

- Theosophical Society was established by American Col. H.S. Olcott and Russian spiritualist Madame H.P. Blavatsky in **1875** in the USA and shifted Headquarters to adyar, Madras. It has been significant for the development of modern India's religion, society, and culture.
- **Objective**
  - To encourage research into ancient philosophies, religions, and science
  - Activate the divine potential that exists within man and create a global human brotherhood.
- **Annie Besant:**
  - After Madame Blavatsky passed away in **1893**, Annie Besant travelled to India and helped to resurrect and revitalize the movement.
  - **In 1907**, she succeeded Olcott as the president of the society. She won the hearts of many by celebrating the **virtues of Krishna and the Gita**.
  - The movement was directed and backed by the Westerners who glorified Indian religious and philosophical traditions. This helped Indians to recover their self-confidence.
  - In the field of education, she made significant contributions and established the **Central Hindu College at Banaras in 1898**.
  - A library of rare Sanskrit books was added to the headquarters of the Theosophical Society, which evolved into a hub of knowledge.

Iswar Chandra Vidyasagar and Women's Upliftment

- Iswar Chandra Vidyasagar, a legendary figure of the middle of the nineteenth century, was born in **Bengal in 1820** to a humble Brahmin family.
- In 1851, he assumed the position of **Principal of the Sanskrit College**. He was a renowned Sanskrit scholar.
- Vidyasagar's thoughts were a synthesis of Western and Indian principles. He had high moral standards, was a profound humanist, and was kind to the underprivileged.
- He spearheaded a campaign favouring **widow remarriage,** which led to the enactment of the **Widow Remarriage Acts, 1856**.
- He also led a battle against polygamy and a **child marriage.**
- Vidyasagar exerted a lot of effort on behalf of **women's education**. In **1849,** he worked with Bethune to set up the **first Indian girls' school, the Bethune School.** He assisted as a government inspector of schools and ran them at his own expense.

Muslim Reform Movements

- **Lately**, among Muslims, reformist social and religious movements had emerged.
- The majority of Muslims feared that Western education would jeopardize their faith because it was antithetical to Islam.
- **Difference between Deoband and Aligarh Movement:**

Deoband Movement	Aligarh Movement
Its aim was the moral and religious renewal of the Muslim community	It sought to advance the standard of living of Muslims as per Western world
It was Revivalist Movement	It was Reformist Movement
Against the modern and Western Education	Focus to provide Modern Education to youth
Encourage spirit of Jihad against the British	Promote liberal thoughts and British government sponsorship

Sikh Reform Movements

- **Gurudwara Reforms Movement:**
  - Gurudwaras were governed by the Udasi Sikh mahants before the 1920s. These mahants treated the Gurdwara offerings and other income of the Gurudwaras as their income.
  - An agitation was launched for freeing the Gurudwaras from these corrupt mahants and for handing over the Gurudwaras to a representative body of Sikhs.
  - **Sikh Gurudwara Amendment act, 1925** that granted the **Shiromani Gurudwara Prabandhak** Committee the authority to oversee Gurudwaras.

- **Nirankari Movement 1851 by Baba Dyaldas:**
  - They emphasised appropriate religious practice, producing Hukamnamas to clarify what was acceptable and establishing a network of worship places staffed by their priests.
  - They grew by cooperating with the Britishers.
- **Akali Campaign:** A fresh reform campaign known as the Akali Campaign was started at the end of the 19th century to clean up the corrupt management of Gurdwaras.
  - When the Akali Movement surfaced in Punjab after 1920, the Sikh movement gained momentum
- **Sikh Sabha:** The Sikh religious reform movement began in the 1870s with the establishment of the two Singh Sabhas in Amritsar and Lahore.
- **Khalsa College's founding in Amritsar in 1892** contributed to the advancement of **Gurumukhi, Sikh education, and Punjabi literature.**
- Several gurus led religious and social reform initiatives among the Sikhs in an effort to strengthen the Sikh religion. **Baba Dayal Das** promoted the concept of a nirankar (formless) God.

Parsi Reform Movements

In **1851**, the Parsi Religious Reform Association was founded. It waged a battle against religious orthodoxy. Following Reforms were initiated:

- **Established Organisation:** Nauroji Furdonji, Dadabhai Naoroji, S.S. Bengalee, and others created the **Rahnumai Mazdayasnan Sabha** or Religious Reform Association for spreading education, particularly among girls.
- **Expansion of Parsi Reform movement** - through message sperad by the newspaper Rast Goftar(Truth-teller)
- **Against Orthodox practices:** They also campaigned against orthodox practices and child marriage in the Parsi religion.
- **Religious Reforms:** Restoration of the Zoroastrian faith to its pristine purity.
- **Against extravagance in functions:** The leaders opposed and grandiose betrothal, wedding, and funeral customs.
- **Scientific Temperament**: They discouraged people from using astrology, and promoted scientific development.

Contribution of Dada Bhai Naoroji

- He was known for Social Reformer, Transnational Connections and Statistical Liberalism.
- **Social Reforms:**
  - **Focus on Girls Education**: Naoroji's endeavour was motivated by his reformist enthusiasm for gender equality. He later opened six girls' schools in October 1849 under the auspices of the **Students' Literary and Scientific Society (SLSS)**.
  - **Religious reforms:** These reforms were implemented to rationalize religious rituals that were thought to be unreasonable in addition to social difficulties.
  - **Establishment of Organisation**: The **Rahnumai Mazdayasnan Sabha** (Society of the Guides of the Mazdayasnan Path) and **Rast Goftar**, a Gujarati journal, were established in 1851 by Naoroji and his associates.
  - **Against Orthodox rituals**: The **Rahnumai Mazdayasnan** sabha campaigned against orthodox practices in the Parsi religion as well as the upliftment of women.

Economic and Political Reforms

Dada Bhai Naoroji contributed significantly as well in the Economic and Political spheres, which can be summarised as -

- **Critics of Economic Policy**: Foremost critic of British economic policy, advocating the 'Drain of Wealth' theory.
- **Political Contribution:**
  - Instrumental in the set-up of 'London Indian Society' with an aim to discuss social and political issues.
  - Assisted to establish 'East India Association" (1867)' to convey the perspective of Indians to the British people.
- Served as a Liberal Party member and Member of Parliament (MP) in the UK House of Commons.

Fight Against Caste Based Exploitation

- **Issues:**
  - According to the Hindu **'chaturvarn ashrama'** concept, a person's caste determines their status and relative purity of different sections of the population.
  - Caste factors governed activities such as clothing, food, place of residence, sources of water for drinking and irrigation, and entry into temples.
  - The scheduled castes/Dalits suffered the most from the discriminatory caste system, facing humiliating and inhumane treatment based on birth inequality.

- **Factors which contributed to the reduction of caste-based discrimination include:**
  - **British rule**: The English rule perhaps unintentionally, created conditions that weakened caste consciousness to some extent.
  - **Social reform movements:** They also worked to dismantle caste-based exploitation. These movements were inspired by the principles of liberty and equality in their fight against the forces that tended to divide society.
  - **Literacy and Scientific temperament**: With increased educational opportunities and general awakening, there were stirrings among the lower castes.
  - **Role of Gandhiji:** He established the **All India Harijan Sangh** in 1932. His crusade for the **"root and branch abolition of untouchability"** was founded on humanism and logic. The removal of untouchability was at the forefront of all public activity for leaders like Gandhi.
  - **Role of reformers:**
    - As part of his fight against upper-caste dominance in Maharashtra, **Jyotiba Phule** launched a lifelong crusade against Brahmanical religious authority.
    - **B.R. Ambedkar** dedicated his life to opposing caste tyranny, founding the All India Scheduled Castes Federation in 1942.
    - The **All India Depressed Classes Association in 1926** was created by several other scheduled caste leaders.
  - **Contemporary evolved human rights concept**: The evolution of values of equality and human rights also helped to remove caste discrimination from society.
  - **Freedom Movement**: It became a key impediment to the development of a sense of nationhood and the spread of democracy in modern India, which promoted the elimination of discrimination based on castes. The Free India Constitution requires equality and non-discrimination on the basis of caste.

Issues of Women in Socio-Religious Movements

- The situation of Indian women at the start of the 19th century was not good.
- Their lives had been rendered extremely dreadful because of evil customs, for instance, Sati practice, the Purdah system, child marriage, female infanticide, bride price, and polygamy.
- Regarding educational, social, and economic prospects, there was no equality between men and women in India.
- **As a result, there were the following significant issues related to Women during the 19th century:**
  - **Gender biases in-laws:**
    - The British honoured the personal laws of Islam and Hinduism.
    - In terms of marriage, divorce, property, succession, and adoption, these rules viewed women as second- class citizens and honoured the rights of the patriarchal family.
- There was a broad understanding between nationalist male elites and the colonial state to confine women to domestic roles and subordination.
  - **Purdah in Public Life:** Indian intellectuals invoked a moral code for women to glorify India's ancient past. To shield her from the "corrupting influence" of the West, both Hindu and Muslim elites in Bengal and Maharashtra popularized the purdah system, promoting female seclusion.
  - **Social Acceptance of Laws:** Despite the legal sanction for widow remarriage by the British, Indian society upheld ascetic widowhood as a status symbol, limiting the law's impact.
  - **Limitations of Reform:** Both British and Indian reformers viewed women's issues as social concerns, without challenging the deeper structures of caste, religion, or patriarchy that sustained gender inequality. There was no real effort to ensure gender justice.
  - **Female Labour Force Participation:** Indian industrialists and plantation owners portrayed women workers as inefficient and unreliable, justifying lower wages compared to men.

Though British officials and Indian intellectuals aimed to improve women's status in the 19th century, their efforts were confined to domestic ideals. Critical issues such as gender equality, religious orthodoxy, and caste bias remained unaddressed.

Role Played by Women

- **Sarla Devi Chaudhrani:** She founded the Bharat Stree Mahamandal in Allahabad in 1910. Its goals included advancing women's education and enhancing the socioeconomic and political standing of women across India.
- **Pandita Rama Bai:**
  - Pandita Rama Bai received her education in both England and the United States. She wrote about the unfair treatment given to Indian women.
  - She established the **Arya Mahila Sabha in Pune and the Sarda Sadan** to aid widows in need.
  - She pleaded for an improvement in the educational condition of Indian women,
  - **Lady Dufferin College** began offering medical education to women on her request.

- **Meherbai Tata:** The National Council of Women in India was established in 1925 as a national affiliate of the International Council of Women.
- **Margret Cousins:** In In 1927, Margraet cousin founded All India women conference brought up the issue of women's voting rights and met with the Viceroy together with Sarojini Naidu to make the case for women's voting rights.

Legislative Measures For Women	
Act passed by the British Administration	**Features**
Bengal Sati Regulation Act (1829)	To ban Sati Practice and made it illegal practice
Hindu Widows Remarriage Act of 1856 (Act XV, 1856)	legalised remarriage of widows
Native Marriage Act (1872)	Intended legislative action for the prohibition but was not applicable to Hindus, Muslims and other recognised religions.
Act of Age of Consent (1891)	Prohibited the marriage of girl child below the age of 12 years
Sharda Act (1929)	Minimum age for marriage was raised to 14 years
Act V of 1843	Practice of slavery was declared illegal

Common Features of Socio - Religious Reform Movements

- **Monotheism:** The belief in one God and the fundamental similarity of all religions was spread by all reformers. They, therefore, made an effort to reduce the gap between various religious perspectives.
- **Religious Reforms:** The priesthood, ceremonies, idolatry, and polytheism were all denounced by the reformers. These reform movements also opposed the caste system and the practice of child marriage which were obvious instances of their humanitarian side.
- **Focus on the status of Women**: The objective of the reformers was to elevate women's and girls' status in society. They all emphasized the importance of educating women.
- **Social Equality:** By challenging the caste system and untouchability, the reformers contributed to the consolidation of India's people into one nation.
- **Self-Respect**: The reform movements promoted among Indians a sense of dignity, liberty, and patriotism.

Impact of Socio-Religious Movements in Indian Freedom Struggle (UPSC 2019)

- **Resurgence of Religions:** Hinduism's revival as a rational, tolerant faith aimed to reclaim its lost prestige following the rise of Christianity and Islam in the nineteenth century.
- **Empowered Marginalized Societies**: An assault on the degrading acts committed against women, untouchables, and other oppressed and marginalized communities in Indian society.
- **Increased Scientific Quotient**: Fostering feelings of selflessness, piety, and rationalism
- **Against Caste system**: The Reform movements acted as a critique of the rigidities of the caste system and hereditary traits.
- **Promoted Tolerance in Society:** Encouraged belief in equality, nativization, and the coexistence of different cultures and religions.
- **Nationalism**: Socio-Religious movements created a national awakening among the population.
- **Development of literature:** These reformers used books, plays, short tales, poetry, and the press to promote their messages.

Limitations of Socio- Religious Movements

- The reform movements were largely male-dominated and failed to prioritize gender equality. For instance, Keshub Chandra Sen of the Brahmo Samaj, despite publicly opposing child marriage and being impressed by Christianity's influence in England, allowed his 14-year-old daughter to marry the son of the Maharaja of Cooch Behar, thus contradicting his stance against child marriage.
- The reform movements had narrow aims. **For example,** educating women to be better wives and mothers rather than promoting gender equality in society.
- Reforms did not address the wider systemic issues of gender discrimination and patriarchy. For instance, dowry was criticised but women's economic dependence on men was left unaddressed.
- The efforts towards women's education were often limited to higher caste women, ignoring the intersectional discrimination faced by women of lower castes and classes.
- The reform movements were often regional and community-specific. Large number of rural women continued to face discrimination and oppression.

Government Attitude Toward Social Reform in India over the Century

- Although the British policies at the start of the 19th century assisted in the removal of social ills, At the same time, they also progressively caused a breach in the socio religious fabric of India because they were mostly based on English vision and attitude.
- **Attitude of the British towards social reforms can be summarised as-**
  - **Downward Filtration theory:** The British intended to train a select group of upper- and middle-class people in order to produce a class of interpreters.
  - **Working Professional**: Socio-Religious reforms made available people for executing British policies and man force for military, and plantation services. For instance, Prohibited activities like the crossing of the sea became the new normal.
  - **Advancement of Missionary activities:** Post Charter Act 1813, Missionaries were allowed the expansion of religious activities and socio-religious reforms made their efforts smooth.
  - **Establish Rule of Law among local people:** Laws for prohibiting child marriages, Sati Customs, Promoting Widow Remarriage etc. were enacted and enforced through action among the masses.

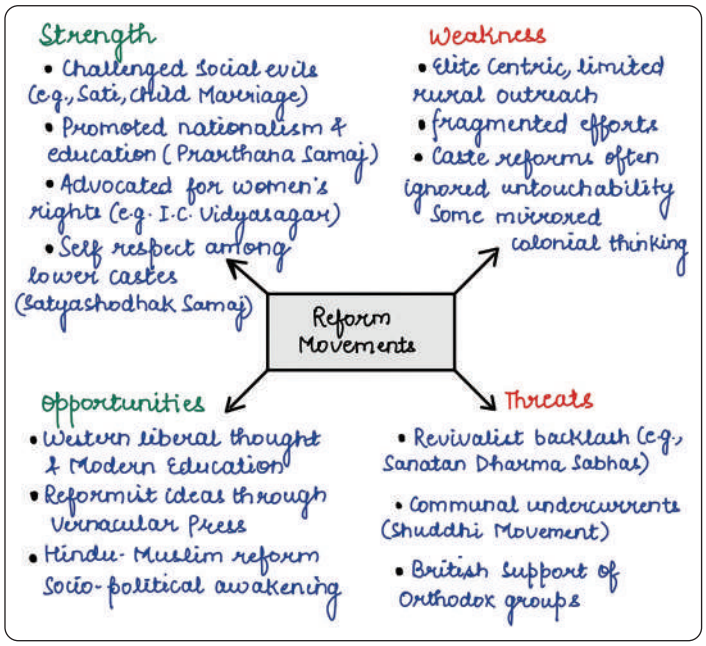

Fig. 4.2: Overview of Reform Movements
Diagram Type: *SWOT*

Conclusion

The socio-religious reform movement as a whole opposed both the religious and social evils of traditional culture's backward elements. The revival of traditional institutions, such as those in medicine, education, philosophy, and so forth, was the main focus. They fought for the democratization of society, the abolition of superstitions and outdated traditions, and the spread of enlightenment. This sparked India's countrywide awakening.

Key Words

Socio-religious reform, caste abolition, women's emancipation, educational reform, Brahmo Samaj, Arya Samaj, Ramakrishna Mission, Young Bengal Movement, Prarthana Samaj, Satyashodhak Samaj, Theosophical Society, Aligarh Movement, Deoband Movement, Widow Remarriage, Child marriage, Untouchability, Missionary activities, Western education, Revivalist and reformist movements, Hindu-Muslim unity, Monotheism, Rationalism, Social equality, National awakening.

	Previous Year Questions	Year
1.	Trace the rise and growth of socio-religious reform movements with special reference to Young Bengal and Brahmo Samaj.	2021
2.	Examine the linkages between 19th centuries 'Indian Renaissance and the emergence of National identity.	2019

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